PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mitsubishi Pajero / Montero (Third Generation)

1999–2006 · V60 · V70 · NM · NP

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Ask for the timing-belt receipt**
  Both US V6s use belts, and owners on Expedition Portal call them interference engines. One owner quotes the manual at 105,000 miles for 2001–2006 Monteros. If there's no proof, budget for a belt, tensioner, pulley, water pump and seals; owners quoted $700 at an independent shop to about $1,400 at a dealer.

- [ ] **Test the brakes cold, and listen for the booster**
  Third-gen trucks use a hydraulic brake booster (HBB) with an accumulator. Recalls covered the accumulator in the US (01V254001), Australia and Hong Kong. Listen for an ABS-pump noise or tone, and check for a hard pedal on the first stop after the truck has been parked. One 2002 owner paid about $2,000 to replace the whole HBB system.

- [ ] **Look under it for oil and ATF cooler leaks**
  Owners on Expedition Portal chase leaks from the engine-oil and transmission-cooler hoses where they run along the frame and join the oil pan and cooler. Bring a Trailer's 2001 Limited had its oil-cooler lines replaced before sale.

- [ ] **Cycle the Super Select lever**
  Go through 2H, 4H, 4HLc and 4LLc on loose ground. CarsGuide's expert says a flashing 4WD light on these trucks usually points to the front-diff actuation system: solenoids, vacuum lines, actuator or diff sensor. BaT's 2001 Limited needed new transfer-case switches.

- [ ] **Feel for driveline clunk**
  Australian NM owners report a clunk when going from off-throttle to on-throttle. One dealer replaced the diff centre and drive rods, which only helped a little. Owners say it didn't get worse with mileage, but factor it into the price.

- [ ] **Check rear ride height**
  Several NM/NP owners on ProductReview say the rear sags with age, and an ExplorOz owner scraped the side steps and towbar until he fitted a 40 mm ARB kit. Look for a nose-up stance and worn rear bushings.

- [ ] **Identify the engine, and don't expect a ladder frame**
  JDMBUYSELL warns buyers that there's no separate chassis, that the 4M41 uses a chain while the V6s use belts, and not to accept a common-rail claim on a 1999 diesel without proof. Check the chassis code on the plate.

- [ ] **Run the VIN for recalls**
  US recalls include the brake-booster accumulator (01V254001, 2001–02), a fuel-tank leveling valve that can leak (04V319000, 2002–04), and label campaigns. In Australia, REC-003136 covers 13,488 NM/NP trucks for the same accumulator.

YEARS TO KNOW

2001	RECALL	First US model year: Montero XLS and Limited, LWB only, 3.5 V6 (200 hp). Consumer Reports rates the Limited 'Not Acceptable' in June. US recall 01V254001 for the brake-booster accumulator (2001–02). Kleinschmidt wins the Dakar
2002	SWEET SPOT	Australia: the 3.2 DI-D replaces the 2.8 diesel and can be had with the five-speed auto. Owners recommend the diesel over the petrols and praise its durability
2002–2004	RECALL	US recall 04V319000: fuel-tank leveling valve can leak when parked nose-up with a full tank

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Hydraulic brake booster accumulator can leak**
  2001–2002 · NHTSA 01V254001
- ☐ **Fuel tank leveling valve may leak**
  2002–2004 · NHTSA 04V319000
- ☐ **Tire and loading label capacity weights wrong**
  2004 · NHTSA 04V095000
- ☐ **Bilingual airbag warning labels too small**
  2001–2004 · NHTSA 04V428000
- ☐ **Owner's manual missing tether-strap headrest instructions**
  2001 · NHTSA 04V067000
- ☐ **Passenger-side exterior mirror non-compliant**
  2001 · NHTSA 00V123002

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Chassis codes**
  JDMBUYSELL lists V63W, V65W, V68W, V73W, V75W and V78W. Bring a Trailer's imports include a V65W three-door 3.5, a V68W three-door 3.2 diesel and a V75W five-door 3.5. Confirm the full code on the frame or VIN plate.
- ☐ **Second or third generation?**
  A 1999 Pajero can be either. Third-generation codes start V6 or V7; BaT's 1999 'Wide Exceed' with a V45 code is a second-generation truck with a separate frame.
- ☐ **US engine from the VIN**
  On BaT's US trucks, the 3.5 Monteros carry R as the eighth VIN character (JA4MW51R…) and the 3.8s carry S (JA4MW51S…, JA4NW31S…).
- ☐ **Pre-facelift or facelift**
  Mitsubishi facelifted the truck for 2003; in the US that's also when the 3.8 and M-ASTC arrived. BaT's 2003 and 2004 Limiteds list M-ASTC.
- ☐ **Grey-import tells**
  Right-hand drive, a fender-mounted mirror and a km/h speedometer (BaT's 1999 V68W has a 180 km/h speedo) mark a Japanese-market truck. Ask for the import paperwork.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/pajero/pajero-gen3/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks